

For C

Hi.

Hello.

Nice to meet you.

Let's be friends.

You remind me of someone
I know
I've known before
but
can't
quite
place
from
when.

I think it's my best friend—
the little girl I played pretend with,
who was motherless like me,
whose lunch I packed
while she packed mine,

Then we taught ourselves to be pretty,
to wear makeup,
to buy bras,
and steeled ourselves
so we'd be ready
to help our real moms stop crying
if they ever got up off the floor.

Or maybe
it's the girl I stood with
in a tiny church
outside Alamogordo
flanking our friend,
the teenage bride.

There to witness
the beginning of the end.

That entire wedding party was too young to vote!

And we all stood a little too close to the altar
our hairspray-laden updos
starting to smoke
the closer we got to the
flames.

You remind me of
a roommate I had once.

The one
I tormented
nightly
with my band practice.

The one
I held tight
as we hurled ourselves
into adulthood.

Or
the one who was waiting up for me
when I came home in the middle of the night
drunk on oxytocin
and beer
neck rubbed raw
from my new boyfriend's stubble,
the one I'd marry 8 months later that year.

Nevermind.

You remind me of a woman
I knew when our boys were tiny.

We would talk for hours on the couch
about how to keep our babies alive,
how exhausted we were,
how much we loved them,
how we couldn't remember life
before them.

How we knew our lives were too small
but it was ok—
mostly because
it had to be.

Or maybe
it's the woman in the restaurant.

The one who saved my life with
a dinner knife and
a swift cut to the trachea.

Unmedicated,
Brave Love.

Something was stuck and I was choking to death.

So she cut.

Decisive,
even though I know her hands were shaking.

And it hurt like hell but I did not die.

I am here to tell the tale
so much more alive
than I ever was before.

Or maybe
you remind me
of the woman I knew last fall.

The one who rebuilt her entire life
from the grit beneath her nails.

She made it look like
sorcery,
forming a new world
from nothing but dust.

Assembling and animating it
with only her breath,
her trust.

But I heard her crying in the RV at night.

And I knew
it was all too immense
to defile with words,

and she'd asked for her privacy,

and the pain was hers not mine,

so I cried
and cried
with her each day
standing just outside.

No.

It's definitely Joan of Arc.
who reminds me of you!

The one who liberated herself and showed me how.

The one who couldn't wait for me
but never stopped leaving signs,
dropping feathers,
snapping twigs,
always hoping we would meet again
a little way down the road.